PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #3 · TRUSTING OTHERS · HIDING THE REAL ME

"I need to hide the real me in order to not get hurt."

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Deep down, do you fear that others, if they got to know you, would hurt, ridicule, or make fun of you? Because of this, do you hide your real feelings or the real you? The information below is intended to help you lessen your fear of others by trusting in God's love and care for you as expressed in the Bible. You don't need to hide from God and, with God's help, you can start to be more open and trusting with other people.

Where it often comes from

If honesty was met with ridicule, rejection, punishment, or betrayal, hiding may once have felt protective. A person may learn to show only a polished version of themselves. Over time, a response to particular experiences can become a rule: being known always leads to being hurt.

How the belief can keep itself going

Hiding feelings, agreeing when we disagree, and pretending to be fine can reduce anxiety briefly. But others have fewer opportunities to understand or support us. Feeling unseen can then seem to prove that closeness is impossible. Small, chosen moments of honesty can help us learn whether a trustworthy person responds with care.

What Scripture teaches

God knows us deeply and invites us to approach Him with confidence. His acceptance gives us a foundation for living more honestly. Scripture also calls believers to welcome one another and share burdens. These passages invite connection; they do not promise that every person will respond well or require us to share everything with everyone.

> *"O LORD, You have searched me and known me. You know when I sit and when I rise; You understand my thoughts from afar." (Psalm 139:1–2)*

Also see

> "Trust in Him at all times, O people; pour out your hearts before Him. God is our refuge. Selah" (Psalm 62:8)

> "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need." (Hebrews 4:16)

> "Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God." (Romans 15:7)

> "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ." (Galatians 6:2)

Common self-statements

- If people really knew me, they would use it against me.
- I must look strong and keep my struggles hidden.
- My honest feelings will drive people away.
- It is safer to be what others expect.
- I should say I am fine even when I need support.
- Being known means losing control.

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralization: Turning past rejection into a rule about all relationships.
- Fortune telling: Treating a feared hurt as certain before it happens.
- Mind reading: Assuming people would reject the real me without checking.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either hide everything or reveal everything.
- Emotional reasoning: Taking the feeling of vulnerability as proof that I am unsafe.
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing experiences of being accepted when I was honest.

Challenging questions

- What part of myself am I afraid to show, and what do I predict will happen?
- Am I assuming this person will react like someone who hurt me before?
- Who has already responded with kindness when I was honest?
- Does keeping everything hidden protect me, or also leave me lonely?
- Can I share one small, ordinary truth instead of everything at once?
- Could someone disagree with me and still care about me?
- How might God's knowledge and acceptance of me change this rule?

Truth summary

I do not have to hide all of myself to be worthy of love or to build meaningful relationships. God knows me and welcomes me. I can allow people who have shown care and respect to know me gradually. Honesty cannot guarantee that I will never be hurt, but hiding everything also has a cost. I can be authentic and still choose healthy boundaries.

A short prayer

Lord, thank You for knowing me and inviting me close. Help me release the need to appear perfect. Give me courage to be honest, wisdom about whom to trust, and openness to receiving love. Amen.

Related Pearls topics

Open these topics in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Friendship
- Love, For Others
- Fear

Godly Counsel Lessons — read or print:

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Communication
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes
>
> Your browser cannot play this audio.

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Click a picture to play inside this card. Each selection is an official lyric video with words on screen.

Known
Tauren Wells

Reflect on being fully known and loved by God rather than needing to keep your real self hidden.

Truth Be Told
Matthew West & Carly Pearce

Challenge the pressure to pretend that everything is fine and consider one honest request for support.

Come As You Are
Crowder

Practice approaching God with your hurts and needs rather than waiting until you look perfect.

Who You Say I Am
Hillsong Worship

Let belonging to God support an identity that does not depend on maintaining a protective image.

YouTube may show ads.

Clinical background

For counselors: beliefs like this are often discussed in connection with what clinicians call paranoid personality disorder. This card follows Identify → Challenge → Replace, using evidence review, balanced alternatives, daily rehearsal, and small behavioral experiments. Hiding the self can occur with suspiciousness, shame, social anxiety, or past relational injury; it is not specific to a personality disorder. This is an individualized educational formulation, not a DSM criterion or a diagnostic test. Psychological difficulties have multiple contributing factors. Sharing personal information is a choice; experiments should involve ordinary, low-stakes honesty with someone who has shown respect.

Beck Institute: Personality Belief Questionnaire materials · Beck, Davis, & Freeman, Cognitive Therapy of Personality Disorders

Each morning ask: "What small part of the real me can I express honestly today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I need to hide the real me in order to not get hurt."

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Check one choice in each section or write your own. Choose a question and a truth that feel meaningful to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it from 0% to 100%.

"I need to hide the real me in order to not get hurt." I believe this _____ %.

2 My best question

Select a question to ask when you feel you must hide.

- ☐ What part of myself am I afraid to show, and what do I predict will happen?
- ☐ Am I assuming this person will react like someone who hurt me before?
- ☐ Who has already responded with kindness when I was honest?
- ☐ Does keeping everything hidden protect me, or also leave me lonely?
- ☐ Can I share one small, ordinary truth instead of everything at once?
- ☐ Could someone disagree with me and still care about me?

My own question:

3 My replacement truth

Select a balanced statement to practice.

- ☐ I can be known and still be loved.
- ☐ My feelings and needs do not make me unworthy of care.
- ☐ I can choose what to share, with whom, and when.
- ☐ Some people can respond to honesty with kindness and respect.
- ☐ I can let trust grow through small experiences of being real.
- ☐ God knows me deeply; I do not need a perfect image to approach Him.

In my own words:

4 My Scripture

Choose one passage to remember; these are the same passages shown on the card.

- ☐ Psalm 139:1–2
  "O LORD, You have searched me and known me. You know when I sit and when I rise; You understand my thoughts from afar."
- ☐ Psalm 62:8
  "Trust in Him at all times, O people; pour out your hearts before Him. God is our refuge. Selah"
- ☐ Hebrews 4:16
  "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."
- ☐ Romans 15:7

"Accept one another, then, just as Christ accepted you, in order to bring glory to God."

☐ Galatians 6:2
"Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."

The verse I will practice:

Practicing the Truth

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5 Rehearse the truth daily

Read your chosen Scripture, listen, and practice a balanced thought.

Read Pearls: Trust. Listen to Overcoming Anxiety. Say your replacement truth aloud once in the morning and once in the evening.

Today I noticed this change:

6 Try a small behavioral experiment

Choose a safe, low-risk test; do not ignore real warning signs.

- ☐ With a person who has respected you, express a small preference instead of automatically agreeing. Predict their response, then record what they actually do.
- ☐ When a trusted friend asks how you are, share one ordinary feeling, such as being tired or a little worried. Notice whether they listen with care.
- ☐ Ask a reliable person for a small favor. Compare what you predicted with the response you received.
- ☐ Admit a minor, everyday mistake to a kind person. Notice whether being imperfect prevents connection.
- ☐ Tell a trusted person about a harmless interest or opinion you usually keep hidden. Look for evidence of curiosity, acceptance, or respectful disagreement.
- ☐ Write an honest prayer about a feeling you hide. Then consider one small part you might choose to share with a trustworthy person.

My prediction:

What actually happened:

What I learned:

7 Track what changes

Practice for seven days. Mark what you tried and rate belief strength.

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

Day	What I practiced	Belief %	What I learned
6			
7			

Song reflection

After listening to one of the four songs, write a sentence about being known, accepted, and honest.

Song:

A truth I want to remember:

My Truth Card

OLD BELIEF:
~~I need to hide the real me in order to not get hurt.~~

NEW TRUTH:
I can be known and loved. I can show the real me gradually to people who have earned my trust.

MY SCRIPTURE:
Psalm 139:1–2

A short prayer

Lord, thank You for knowing and loving me. Help me practice honest connection today, receive kindness, and remember that I do not have to appear perfect to be worthy of care. Amen.

Scripture quotations: Berean Standard Bible (BSB), public domain. Educational material only; not a diagnosis or substitute for professional care.